



For Parents, Carers and Guardians

Nude Images, Sextortion and Online Blackmail: A Guide for Parents

Responding calmly to pressure for nudes, images shared without consent, sextortion and online blackmail, and working with the school.

Before You Read This guide covers nude images of children, sextortion and online blackmail.

This guide is about nude and semi-nude images of children and young people: pressure to send them, images shared without consent, fake images, sextortion and online blackmail. It doesn't show or describe any images. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with your own experience or your child's.

- If you are worried about your child now, contact the school's safeguarding team. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.
- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000, for anyone worried about a child.
- **Samaritans:** 116 123, free, any time, day or night.

About This Guide

Many young people are asked for nude images, and some send them. This guide helps you respond calmly if your child:

- is being pressured to send a nude image;
- has had an image shared without their consent, or has had a fake image made of them;
- is being blackmailed: threatened with an image, video or old post being shared unless they pay or do something (**sextortion** when it involves sexual images);
- has received, shared or made an image of someone else.

Your reaction matters most. Children often don't tell because they fear anger, blame or losing their phone.

If Your Child Is Being Blackmailed Now

- **Stay calm and tell them it isn't their fault.** Sextortion is usually run by organised criminals who target many young people.
- **Don't pay, and don't let them send anything more.** Paying rarely ends it.
- **Stop contact and block** the account, but **don't delete** messages or the account: deactivate it if needed.
- **Report it to the police:** 101, or 999 if there is a threat to life. Tell the school's safeguarding team too.
- If your child is distressed or talks about hurting themselves, stay with them. If their life may be at risk, call 999.

Advice from the National Crime Agency.

Key Words

Nudes

Nude or semi-nude photos, videos or livestreams of young people under 18, including altered and AI-made images.

Sharing without consent

Passing on someone's intimate image without their agreement, or threatening to. It is abuse, and a crime.

Sextortion

Blackmail using sexual images, usually for money. Offenders often pose as young people.

Report Remove

A free Childline and Internet Watch Foundation tool that helps under-18s get their images taken down.

What the Evidence Shows

397

sextortion reports actioned by the IWF (Internet Watch Foundation) in 2025, across all its reporting routes, up 127% on 2024

IWF, 2025

92%

of the IWF's sextortion reports over the last three years (a wider group than the 2025 figure) involved boys, mostly aged 14 to 17

IWF, 2025

Signs to Look For

- Anxiety, fear or secrecy around their phone; changing accounts or numbers
- Suddenly withdrawn, avoiding school or friends, or being talked about by other students
- A sudden need for money, or asking to use a bank account or card
- Late-night phone use, or a new online "friend" you don't know
- Low mood, or saying everything is ruined

A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before contacting the school.

If Your Child Tells You

- **Stay calm.** Your calm helps them feel safe. Say: "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- **Don't blame them.** Avoid "Why did you send it?" Blame is what stops children telling. The person who shared or threatened is responsible.
- **Don't take their phone away** as a response to them telling you. It can feel like a punishment and stop them telling you next time.
- **Reassure them about the law.** Young people should not be in trouble for asking for help if an image of them has been shared. The law is there to protect them.
- Ask gently what they need, and what they're most worried about.

What to Do with Images and Messages

Never View, Save or Forward

- **Don't look at, screenshot, save, copy or forward a nude image of a child**, even your own child, and even as evidence. It can be a criminal offence, and it adds to their distress.
- **Don't delete anything yet.** Keep messages as they are, and note when they arrived. The school or police will advise.
- **Help your child report it:**

- **Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation):** for under-18s in the UK, to report a nude or sexual image or video of themselves and try to get it removed from the internet, at childline.org.uk. You need a Childline account, and Childline counsellors can support you.
- **Take It Down (run by the US National Center for Missing & Exploited Children):** for anyone under 18, anywhere, including the UK, if a nude image of them has been or might be shared online. It makes a digital fingerprint of the image on the device, so the image is not uploaded, and it works only with the platforms that take part, not on encrypted services: takeitdown.ncmec.org.
- **CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency):** ceop.police.uk, to report online sexual abuse, grooming or sexual blackmail. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking. If someone is in immediate danger, call 999.

If Another Child Is Involved

Check With the School First

If another child may be involved or at risk, for example your child has been sent, has shared or has made an image of someone else, **contact the school's safeguarding team before raising it with your child**. Agree how and when to talk to them, so the conversation doesn't put anyone at more risk, spread the image further, or lead to evidence being lost.

- **Don't contact the other child or their family, and don't post about it.** It can make things worse and affect what the school and police can do.
- Then talk calmly about consent, trust and how the other child may feel. Children who share images have sometimes been pressured themselves; they still need to take responsibility.
- **Shore (Lucy Faithfull Foundation):** anonymous advice for teenagers worried about their own sexual behaviour online or offline, including sharing nudes, at shorespace.org.uk.

How the School Responds

Schools using **RESPOND** follow a seven-step approach that helps staff respond consistently when they notice or are told about harm.

For children, safeguarding is **relational**: they tell people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: behind every trusted adult is a safeguarding team, with records and procedures that

make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help. That is why staff can't promise to keep something just between them and your child.

Step	What staff do
● Recognise	Notice the signs, and treat threats, blackmail and shared images as urgent
● Engage	Listen calmly, believe the child, and never ask to see an image
● Support	Make sure the child is safe today, including their wellbeing
● Pause	Never view, copy or delete images, or investigate; the safeguarding lead decides
● Offer	Model alternatives, explain what happens next, and help with removal
● Notify	Tell the safeguarding team immediately
● Document	Record what happened, factually, without describing any image

Working with You

- **Parents and carers are partners in keeping children safe.** You know your child best.
- The school will usually involve you when there is a concern about your child.
- Schools can share safeguarding information without asking for consent where it is needed to keep a child safe; data protection law allows this. From 30 September 2026, a new Information Sharing Duty also requires many safeguarding organisations to share relevant information. What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Schools should tell you what they are sharing and why, unless that would put a child at greater risk, and listen to your views and your child's.
- Sometimes the school must speak to other agencies before telling parents, where telling parents first could increase the risk to a child. That decision depends on the circumstances, and it is always about the child's safety.
- Schools follow national advice for incidents involving nude images. Staff won't ask your child to show them images, and won't copy or forward them. A safeguarding lead decides on next steps, including whether the police or children's social care need to be involved.
- You will usually be told at an early stage. Every child involved gets a response: the child pictured, and any children who shared or received the image.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"My child will be prosecuted for sending an image"	The law aims to protect children. The police focus on safeguarding, and children should not be in trouble for asking for help.
"Paying will make it go away"	Offenders usually ask for more. Don't pay: report it.
"I should look at the image to understand what happened"	Don't. Viewing or saving it can be an offence and adds to your child's distress.
"Taking the phone away will fix it"	It can feel like punishment for telling. Plan changes together.
"Nothing can be done once it's online"	Report Remove and Take It Down can help get images removed or blocked.



Who Can Help

At School

- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep children safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Police:** 999 if someone is in immediate danger; 101 to report sextortion or blackmail that is not an emergency
- **NSPCC Helpline:** 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- **YoungMinds Parents Helpline:** 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- **Samaritans:** 116 123, free, any time, day or night
- **Childline** (for your child): 0800 1111, free, confidential, any time, or [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk)

Contacts checked September 2026.

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Parent Guides

Nude Images, Sextortion and Online Blackmail: A Guide for Parents: Parent Guide 10 - Ages 8 to 18

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